Then, after a break, in which I took my turn down in the pit observing other soldiers' shots, I was forced to take a new rifle at random to complete my shooting.

I said that I wanted my own rifle, which I had zeroed in perfectly, but since that was rational it merely confused the sergeant. He just pointed to some rifle lying on the ground and said, "Get started, soldier!" in the Army ape-language you get to understand after a while. Naturally, I found the sights in the strange rifle adjusted to hit the next county and I wasted shots correcting that.

In the end, I got a score of 160, which earned me a "sharpshooter"

score and a special kind of gizmo to hang on my chest. I never enjoyed it, though. I would have done much better if I could have injected a few brains into the heads of the noncoms in charge. (Not likely, of course, for their heads were solid and would have quickly rejected the foreign substance even if they had been hollow.)

7

By now, one Gerald Cohen was a good friend of mine. When there was an offer of a weekend pass (that is, from Saturday noon to Monday morning) I would have been delighted to take it, had I but known how to get home. I could take the train in Washington and get to New York in four hours, but how did I get from Camp Lee to Washington?

I was on the point of rejecting the pass (if I couldn't go to New York to see Gertrude, there was no point in going anywhere) when Gerry said he was going to New York and he would show me how. I accepted both the pass and his offer eagerly, therefore.

Gerry took me down to Petersburg on December 1, therefore, took me to the bridge leading out of town, and explained how one hitched a ride. You stood there, he said, with your thumb aiming in the direction you wanted to go, and you tried to look pathetic.

"Now you stand here and practice," he said, "and 111 just step into the drugstore for a minute, then I'll come out and show you how to do it right"

He stepped into the drugstore and he may have come out in a minute, but by then I was gone. A car driven by a Navy lieutenant, junior grade, stopped almost at once and picked me up, so that I was off on my first furlough from the Army. The war had not yet receded so far into the distance that soldiers